Time Journal (T-30/T-60)

A Tool for Transparency, Accountability, and Trust-Building

Preface

I struggle with my own personal integrity and identity. I know I need to do something else, something different than what I was doing. When I came across the T-30 Journal in *Worthy of Her Trust*, I immediately blew it off as something necessary for "other people," people who have had affairs. Why else would someone need to record where they were and what they were doing every 30 minutes?

Yet, I could not shake the idea that I should do the T-30 Journal, so I reviewed the tool again "to learn more about it" when I really was looking for a reason, any reason, *not* to do it.

Then, I listened to Thomas teach about the T-30 Journal. I again listened trying to find a reason *not* to do it. In my obstinance and stubbornness, I didn't even hear the heart behind the tool. I delayed and delayed.

Yet, I still had this nagging thought that I should do the T-30 Journal, but I simply didn't want to do it for *every 30 minutes*. So, I decided I would study it, think about it, and communicate to another person as if I were the one providing the advice and guidance.

This exercise revealed to me that I was someone who really did not want to be held accountable because I wanted to do what I wanted to do when I wanted to do it how I wanted to do it. It also pulled me out of myself and my "stinking thinking" changing my mindset and perspective. Finally, I also realized that this tool could help *me* build *my* personal integrity, develop *my* character, and rebuild trust and confidence *in myself* and become a trustworthy person.

So, I wrote this introduction *to convince myself* that I should do the ~~T-30~~ T-60 Journal. My hope and prayer are that this introduction and journal itself will help you become the person God has called us to be.

Introduction to the Time Journal (T-30/T-60)

At its core, the Time Journal is, first and foremost, a tool for *developing intimacy with God, self and others*. It's a structured, time-based journal that documents your day in 30-minute (T-30) or 60-minute (T-60) increments. It's *not* simply a log of activity. It's a living record of how you are choosing to live—how you spend your time, with whom you interact, and how you experience those moments. The Time Journal is a simple yet powerful tool that cultivates emotional awareness and demonstrates a commitment to integrity and authenticity while holding you accountable to living transparently and honestly with your time and behavior.

Why is the Time Journal Important?

The Time Journal serves multiple crucial purposes as you rebuild intimacy with God, self and others, especially with your spouses. Many people initially think the Time Journal is "for him/her," that is, for the betrayer to reassure their spouse and rebuild lost trust. While the journal can do that, it misses the deeper and primary purpose. The Time Journal is, first and foremost, ***for you***. When faithfully, accurately, and honestly completed, the Time Journal becomes more than a mere accountability tool. It becomes a spiritual discipline that fosters *your* **sanctification**, builds *your* **integrity**, develops *your* **character**, reveals your **identity**, and improves *your* **relationships** to become someone worthy of his/her trust.

The Time Journal is about *your integrity, your character growth, your identity in Christ and your own personal intimacy within yourself*.

Personal Sanctification

The Time Journal is first and foremost about your sanctification and your ongoing transformation into Christlikeness. Before it serves anyone else, it serves your soul. This journal is about

your integrity before God (Ps 15:1-2), your character growth in Christ (Rom 5:3-4), your identity in Christ (2 Cor 5:17), and your own personal intimacy with yourself and with God (Jas 4:8; Jn 15:5).

Combating Intimacy Aversion

Many who struggle with sexual sin also struggle with intimacy aversion—a deep resistance to being truly known. The Time Journal directly confronts this pattern by fostering self-intimacy, where you connect with yourself through the spiritual and emotional discipline of rigorous honesty. When you record your time consistently with clarity and truthfulness, you are not merely creating a record; you are forming yourself into a person who can be trusted *because you can trust yourself to tell the truth*.

Building Spiritual Muscle

Completing the Time Journal daily is sanctifying work. As you meticulously document your day—the mundane and the meaningful, the commendable and the compromising—you are getting stronger. You are building muscles of humility, honesty, and diligence. You are developing *your own* character, not merely providing external reassurance to someone else. And yes, it will be difficult. If it were easy, it wouldn't be worth doing

This is the work of spiritual formation. Each entry is an act of submission to the truth. Each moment of transparency is a small death to the old self that operated in shadows and half-truths. The Time Journal is one practical way we remove the masks, drop the pretense, and allow the light of truth to do its transforming work.

The Practice of Self-Examination

The Time Journal functions as a daily spiritual discipline similar to the Puritan practice of self-examination. It creates intentional moments throughout your day to pause and ask:

"What have I been doing? Where have I been? Who have I been with? What has been going on in my heart?" This regular rhythm of accountability to yourself (and ultimately to God) develops the kind of self-awareness that James 1:23-24 describes when He warns against being a hearer who looks at himself/herself in a mirror and immediately forgets what he/she looks like. The Time Journal prevents such forgetfulness.

When faithfully practiced, this tool helps you become someone worthy of trust—not through performance or pretense, but through genuine transformation from the inside out.

Integrity

The root word of integrity is "integer"—meaning something complete and undivided, like a whole number as opposed to a fraction. Having integrity means being whole, self-integrated, complete, singular, and congruent—not fractured, compartmentalized, or disintegrated.

For many in sin, the fractured life has become second nature. You've been one person at church, another at work, another online, and yet another behind closed doors. Separate compartments. Different versions. A life divided against itself.

Striving for integrity requires working toward integration—reconstructing the fragments, deconstructing all the compartments, bringing your thoughts, beliefs, and actions into alignment, and becoming the same person regardless of your location, environment, or company. The Christian life demands coherence, not compartmentalization.

Integrity is a profound inward wholeness that expresses itself in conviction, stability, and unwavering righteousness. It is what the psalmist prays for: "May integrity and uprightness preserve me, for I wait for you" (Ps 25:21). It is what Job clung to in his suffering: "I hold fast my righteousness and will not let it go; my heart does not reproach me for any of my days" (Job 27:6).

Living Coram Deo

Living with integrity is living *coram Deo*—before the face of God—with nothing to hide and nothing to fear. As R.C. Sproul said, "To live *coram Deo* is to live one's entire life in the presence of God, under the authority of God, to the glory of God." This is what David understood when he wrote, "Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence?" (Ps 139:7). God sees everything. He knows everything.

It's living in the Light and in the Truth—*lux et veritas* (Jn 3:21; 8:32; 1 Jn 1:5-8). Jesus declares, "I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life" (Jn 8:12). John adds, "If we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 Jn 1:7). Walking in the light means bringing everything—every hour, every conversation, every choice—out of the shadows and into the truth.

The Time Journal as Integrity Training

And is there a better practical tool for this than documenting your day? The Time Journal is integrity training. It forces you to name what you've done, where you've been, who you've spoken with. It eliminates the vague half-truths that sexual sin thrives on. It demands specificity. It requires you to be the same person on paper that you were in reality. Every honest entry is an act of integration. Every moment of transparency is practice in becoming whole.

As *Worthy of Her Trust* states, "A lack of integrity in one area often indicates a lack of integrity in all areas" (p. 174). The Time Journal reveals whether you are living as one man or many—and gives you the daily opportunity to choose wholeness over fragmentation.

Character Growth

Christian character is becoming an authentic and sincere person, someone whose heart is undivided in simple devotion to God (2 Cor 11:3), beyond reproach (1 Tim 3:2), aligned with God's truth, without hypocrisy or hidden motives (1 Pet 2:1), characterized by consistency in thought, word, and deed (Jas 1:22). It is who you are when no one is looking—or who you are behind the steering wheel when traffic is bad, or alone in a hotel room, or scrolling your phone at 11 PM.

The Scriptures are clear about the kind of people God calls us to be. Paul writes, "Therefore, laying aside falsehood, speak truth each one of you with his neighbor, for we are members of one another" (Eph 4:25, NASB). Peter exhorts us to "Keep your conduct among the Gentiles honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation" (1 Pet 2:12, ESV). This is the character we're called to—not perfection, but progression; not pretense, but authenticity.

If completed with honesty and practiced consistently, the Time Journal enables us to develop our character and see our own growth, not merely provide external reassurance to others.

Character is forged, not found—and the Time Journal is one of the anvils on which it is hammered out. So how does the Time Journal fashions our character?

1. Develops Accountability

By honestly tracking your time in transparent detail, you become more accountable for your choices. The journal shifts the burden of proof from defense to demonstration. As noted in *Worthy of Her Trust*, "You can't prove what you aren't doing wrong, but you can certainly prove what you are doing right" (p. 174). Instead of protesting your innocence, you provide evidence of your faithfulness.

2. Breaks Patterns of Deception

Most deception happens in vague timelines, especially in our own recollections. "I was at work" becomes cover for a multitude of sins when no one asks what specifically you were doing at work. The journal brings clarity where ambiguity used to exist, eliminating the "gray areas" and generalities that previously enabled acting out, lying, or other destructive behaviors. Light exposes what darkness conceals (Eph 5:13).

3. Demonstrates Consistent Discipline

The daily and hourly practice of documenting your activities builds habits of consistency. Character is not formed in isolated moments of heroism but in the accumulation of small, faithful choices. As Paul writes, "Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labor is not in vain" (1 Corinthians 15:58, ESV). The Time Journal trains you in steadfastness.

4. Cultivates Diligence

Recording your activities is simple work, but recording activities plus context plus emotion involves significant effort, insight, and often leads to more work. It shows intentionality toward, responsibility for, and ownership of your own recovery.

5. Practices Humility and Honesty

Submitting yourself to the practice of hourly meticulous documentation demands humility and complete honesty. You must humble yourself to write, "10:00-10:30: Scrolled social media when I should have been working." Humility means admitting the mundane failures alongside the significant victories. "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble" (Jas 4:6, ESV).

6. Increases Awareness

The Time Journal creates regular check-in points throughout your day, making you more aware of your choices and creating a barrier to acting out. When you know you'll have to write down what you did from 2:00-2:30, you're less likely to spend that time looking at what you shouldn't. Awareness is the first step toward change.

7. Fosters Personal Congruence

As your awareness grows, you become aware of the misalignment between your internal values and external actions—and then you can bring them into alignment. This journal invites you to ask, "Am I living in alignment with what I say I believe or say I will do?" Or, “Am I living worthy of the gospel of Christ?” (Phil 1:27).

8. Develops Personal Ownership

Logging your own behavior develops self-awareness and reduces defensiveness. When you've already written down what you did, there's no need to be defensive when asked about it. You own your choices rather than deflecting responsibility for them.

9. Improves Productivity

When you account for your time, you often discover wasted moments and reclaim them, resulting in increased productivity and efficiency. Just as a food journal makes people more conscious of what they eat, the Time Journal makes you more conscious of how you spend your hours. Paul's words ring true: "Look carefully then how you walk, not as unwise but as wise, making the best use of the time, because the days are evil" (Eph 5:15-16, ESV).

10. Enables Proactive Transparency

Instead of requiring your spouse to "check up" on you, the journal enables you to offer clarity before it's requested—and this must be done proactively. Don't just pass your journal to your spouse saying, "Here's my day," or "See, I didn't do anything wrong today." That's defensive posturing, not genuine transparency. Instead, approach it with humility: "Here's what my day looked like. Let me know if you have any questions or if there's anything you'd like me to clarify."

The Fruit of Faithful Practice

When practiced faithfully over time, the Time Journal doesn't just record character—it forms it. You become the kind of person who tells the truth reflexively, who lives transparently naturally, who owns their choices readily.

Identity

Who are you? Not who do others think you are. Not who you pretend to be. Not the carefully curated image you've projected for years. Who are you *really*?

Reputation vs. Reality

Reputation matters. Scripture is clear about this: "A good name is to be chosen rather than great riches" (Prov 22:1, ESV). But not at the expense of integrity and character. Not when maintaining your reputation requires living a lie.

For many of us, so much energy has been expended protecting and controlling our reputation that our entire identity has become wrapped up in the illusion we've created. We've become masters of image management, public relations experts of our own lives. This creates a devastating dissonance—a chasm inside us where our actual performance does not align with the idealistic expectations and reputation we've crafted. And when that gap threatens to be exposed, we manipulate, lie,

hide, avoid, excuse, criticize, or blame others to manage our image.

The False Core Beliefs

Beneath this exhausting performance often lie toxic core beliefs that have driven us for years:

- “I am basically a bad, unworthy person.”
- “No one would love me as I am.”
- “If they really knew me, they would leave me.”
- “My needs are never going to be met if I have to depend upon others.”

These lies—and they are lies (Rom 8:1; 1 Jn 3:1; Ps 139:13-16)—shape our behavior in devastating ways. We control, manipulate, and deceive others because we're terrified of being truly known. We hide bad things from people because we fear rejection, which is itself a form of control and manipulation. But here's what many of us don't realize: we also hide *good* things from people because we want to exert power and control over them. Information becomes currency. Secrets become leverage. And in the darkness, our false self thrives.

The Time Journal as a Mirror of Truth

The Time Journal forces you to see your true behavior and face these dysfunctional tactics head-on. It becomes a daily confrontation with reality. Every entry poses uncomfortable questions:

- Will I lie as I write this?
- Will I slant what I'm doing to make myself look better?
- Will I exaggerate the time I spent on this good thing?
- Will I minimize the time I spent on this bad thing?
- Will I conveniently "forget" to record certain activities altogether?

These questions matter because they reveal whether you're committed to truth or still clinging to image management. They

expose whether your identity is rooted in Christ or still tethered to the false self you've been maintaining.

From False Self to True Identity

The Christian life is a journey from the false self to the true self—the self God created you to be. Paul writes, "You have put off the old self with its practices and have put on the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge after the image of its creator" (Colossians 3:9-10, ESV). Later he adds, "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come" (2 Corinthians 5:17, ESV).

Your true identity is not "addict," "failure," or "hopeless case." Your true identity is not even "recovering sex addict." Your true identity, if you are in Christ, is: beloved son of God (1 John 3:1), forgiven and redeemed (Ephesians 1:7), a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17), seated with Christ in the heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6), more than a conqueror (Romans 8:37).

The Time Journal trains you to live from this new identity rather than the old one. Each honest entry is an act of putting off the false self and putting on the new. Each moment of transparency is practice in being who God says you are rather than who fear tells you to be.

When you write, "2:00-2:30: Wasted time scrolling, felt anxious, avoided the hard conversation I needed to have with my boss," you are living in the light. You are telling the truth about yourself. You are refusing to manage your image. And in that refusal, you are becoming real.

The Freedom of Being Known

Here's the paradox: the very thing we fear—being fully known—is the pathway to freedom. As long as you hide, you remain enslaved to the exhausting work of maintaining your false self. But "if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 John 1:7, ESV).

The Time Journal invites you into this freedom. It says: Stop performing. Stop hiding. Stop managing. Just tell the truth about who you are and what you're doing. Let yourself be known—by God, by yourself, by your spouse. And discover that being fully known is not the death of you. It's the birth of you.

Your true self—the one God created and is redeeming—doesn't need reputation management. He just needs to walk in the light.

Relational Growth

For those who have violated your spouse's trust, especially through sexual betrayal, one haunting question dominates your spouse's mind: "What were you doing when I wasn't there?" This question echoes in moments of silence, surfaces during your commute home from work, and lingers when you're late getting back from an errand. It's the question beneath a thousand other questions, and it demands an answer—not once, but daily.

The Time Journal directly addresses this concern.

Rebuilding the Trust Sculpture

Each honest entry in your journal is like adding another block to your trust sculpture. While no single entry will restore trust entirely, the cumulative effect of consistent honesty over time gradually rebuilds what was shattered. As *Worthy of Her Trust* reminds us, "We have to remember that it's not our hurting wife's responsibility to trust us again. The burden is on us. We bear the responsibility to rebuild the trust and create a new relational sculpture. And the new one won't look like the old one. It will have some similar elements, but the two will be markedly different. They have to be" (p. 190).

This is patient, humble work. There are no shortcuts. But the Time Journal provides a concrete way to demonstrate that you are doing the work.

How the Time Journal Rebuilds Relational Trust

1. Creates Accountability and Removes Mystery

Unaccounted time often becomes a source of anxiety and suspicion for the betrayed spouse. Every gap in the timeline triggers the question: "What was he doing then?" By documenting your activities throughout the day, you remove the mystery surrounding your whereabouts and actions. You answer the question before it's asked.

Additionally, the journal creates a written record that can be referred to in conversation or used to validate (or invalidate) a statement you made, *not to counter* an accusation from your spouse (which should be met with empathy and ownership). When you say, "I was in the team meeting from 2:00 to 3:30," and your journal confirms it—with the names of who was there and what was discussed—trust begins to form. Even with a written record, the temptation to lie or embellish still exists. The journal holds you accountable to yourself first, then to your spouse.

2. Relieves Your Spouse of the Investigator Role

Your spouse ***does <u>not</u> want*** *to be a private investigator.* She did not sign up for that job. Yet many spouses feel thrust into this role after betrayal, constantly wondering and questioning: "Where has he been? What was he doing? Who was he with?" This is exhausting and dehumanizing work.

The Time Journal, when completed and shared properly, alleviates the need for interrogation. It shifts the responsibility of accountability to where it belongs—with you. Instead of her having to ask, you proactively offer. It takes the burden off of her and moves the responsibility of accountability to where it belongs—*with you*.

3. Demonstrates Tangible Commitment to Change

Words are cheap. "I'm sorry" and "I'll never do it again" have lost their currency in your relationship. Your spouse has heard these promises before, often while the betrayal was still ongoing. She needs more than words now. She needs evidence.

The Time Journal is tangible action. It shows you're willing to do the difficult, humbling work necessary to restore the relationship. Every entry is proof of effort. Every day of consistent documentation is evidence that this time is different.

4. Establishes a Pattern of Transparency

Betrayal thrives in secrecy. Recovery requires transparency. Over time, the journal helps establish a new pattern in your relationship—a pattern of openness rather than concealment. The Time Journal creates regular check-in points throughout your day, making you more aware of your choices and creating a natural barrier to acting out. Transparency becomes not just reactive (answering questions) but proactive (living openly).

5. Rebuilds Trust Through Consistency

Trust is rebuilt through the accumulation of trustworthy behavior over time. By showing detailed, honest time logs day after day, week after week, month after month, you offer evidence of integrity in a relationship that has lost it. Small marbles of trust go back into the bucket—not all at once, but one at a time.

However—and this is critical—if you are not honest, consistent, or truly transparent in your journal, then the trust that could have been rebuilt is lost, often more catastrophically than before. Half-truths in the journal are worse than no journal at all. They represent a continuation of the betrayal under the guise of recovery.

6. Creates Opportunities for Relational Intimacy

The Time Journal becomes a springboard for meaningful conversations, not just status updates or defensive

mechanisms. When shared and discussed properly, it opens doors to deeper connection.

For example, instead of simply handing over your journal saying, "Here's my day" or "See, I didn't do anything wrong today" (both defensive postures), you might say: "Today was challenging. You'll see in my journal that I had an unexpected conversation with Sarah from accounting. I want to talk about how I handled it and how I was feeling. Can we debrief that together?"

This transforms the journal from a surveillance tool into an intimacy tool. You're not just reporting data; you're inviting your spouse into your inner world—your thoughts, your struggles, your victories, your growth. This is what Paul means when he writes, "Therefore, having put away falsehood, let each one of you speak the truth with his neighbor, for we are members one of another" (Ephesians 4:25, ESV).

Caught Doing Right

Finally, the Time Journal creates opportunities to be caught doing the right thing for the right reasons with the right heart. Instead of your spouse discovering your failures (as happened repeatedly during your acting out), she now discovers your faithfulness. She sees evidence of you choosing well, living transparently, and growing in character.

Over time, this shifts the narrative of your relationship. The story is no longer only about what you did wrong. It begins to include chapters about what you're doing right—not perfectly, but progressively. Not without struggle, but with increasing integrity.

And in that new story, trust finds room to grow again.

What about...? Objections to the Time Journal

Despite its effectiveness, you may initially resist the Time Journal revealing the state and condition of your heart. You

likely fall in one of two groups: (1) a person who is seeking to grow, build personal integrity, and/or rebuilding trust on your own, or (2) a person who was told to do time journaling. Your initial thoughts and emotions reveal your heart.

You may be frustrated and angry—“Why do I have to do this!?”—or depressed and sad—“No matter what I do, it’s not good enough.”—or somewhere in between.

Your response may be like the victim who’s passively trying to avoid responsibility. They think or say, "I can’t do that” or “I can’t live my life under a microscope” trying to manipulate and solicit sympathy or pity. For the victim, the Time Journal is one more thing that is piling up on them to do.

You may respond like a martyr who’s actively and even aggressively trying to control through anger or manipulate through placating. “Okay. Fine! I’ll do it! But she can’t say anything about it!” Or more subtly, “I’ll do it if she needs me to do it.” They want to be free and independent of any yokes placed upon them. They offer to do whatever simply hoping their spouse, counselor, sponsor or coach will back off. For the martyr, this is a checklist item that entitles them to integrity and trust.

Regardless, the victim and martyr mentalities are both wanting to avoid accountability, transparency, and being known. They are afraid of rejection, abandonment, or failure. They do not want one more thing that will make them feel insignificant, incompetent or even impotent.

Instead, our hope is that you see this as an opportunity and a tool that will reveal these wrong motivations as a means to grow closer to the Lord and become a person of integrity.

Let's address some common objections:

“Do I really need to record every time I go to the bathroom?”

Yes. It’s not about the bathroom. It’s about closing gaps in your day that could otherwise be filled with doubt. What seems silly is actually a critical trust-building detail.

“This feels invasive and controlling.”

Many feel the Time Journal infringes on their privacy and independence. It is! If you've violated trust in any way, especially through sexual betrayal, you've forfeited the right to complete privacy. The journal isn't about control; it's about rebuilding security and safety in your relationship.

“This is humiliating.”

It doesn’t have to be. It can be embarrassing. It’s humbling—and that’s the point. This is not a punishment. It’s a pathway to freedom, clarity, and deeper connection

“How can she trust what I write anyway?”

This is a legitimate question. If, in the past, you've lied about your whereabouts or whom you were with, nothing written in a journal is trustworthy, initially. Your primary goal should not be rebuilding trust but becoming a man of integrity, a man of God, or growing in your relationship with Christ. Then the work of the Time Journal is valuable in and of itself for you. The primary purpose isn't just about verifying your exact location but demonstrating your willingness to be accountable for your life, calendar, and use of time.

“This is a waste of time.”

Many spouses will think that this is a complete waste of time because “it means nothing” or “it does nothing.” You may even think that it is a complete waste of time if what you write cannot be trusted. However, inevitably, weeks, months, or even years into the process, they will look at the journal, and when

they do, they will see that he/she has done it consistently and will be grateful for it. Consistency with the seemingly small task of keeping a Time Journal demonstrates your commitment to the bigger work of rebuilding trust and is meaningful in and of itself.

“I can't remember to document every 30 minutes.”

This is where practicality meets intention. What can you do to help you remember? You could carry a flip notepad, write short notes in an app, or many other things. Regardless, if you are forgetful, you must do everything you can to remember so you can record it in the journal. The goal is not perfection per se but consistency and completeness. If you miss an entry and forget, record that!

“This feels like punishment.”

Rather than viewing the Time Journal as punishment, consider it an opportunity. On the Redemptive Living Radio, Jason said, “Living in such a way that anything in my life could be scrutinized deterred me from some old, unhealthy behaviors and also helped me develop some new, healthy ones.” The journal isn't about paying penance but about creating new patterns of integrity.

“I don’t have time for this.”

Actually, you do! You have time to do whatever you want or love to do. You had time to act out. You have time to go to the bathroom. If you don’t have time for this, then it is simply not a priority for you, which again reveals your heart. When you make the time for this, you, like many others, will find that this practice saves time by eliminating wasted hours and bringing clarity to priorities.

How do I Use Time Journal Properly?

First, the most important thing is that you ***just start doing it***. And the fact that you are reading this, you are on your way! Or,

if you are like me, you are procrastinating. If you are procrastinating, stop reading and start writing right now.

Keys to be Effective

There are the five primary keys to making the Time Journal effective: be consistent, be honest, do in real-time, include emotions, and share it with your spouse.

1. **Be Consistent**. We have been consistently inconsistent with most of our life and especially in the areas of trust or accountability. This is a tool that demands consistency, or it will work against you. It will prove your own personal intention. Consistency in making these entries daily builds trust more than perfection. Make the Time Journal a non-negotiable part of your daily routine.
2. **Be Honest**. This will not work if you are not honest. Period. Since the journal is first and foremost for you, then honesty should be the simplest thing, a given. It will help you remember things! What's required to be honest? It means telling the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth. So be truthful, detailed, transparent.
    a. **Be Truthful**. Describe the events, don't interpret the events.
    b. **Be Detailed**. Include essential details, not just details that you believe to be essential but details that your spouse would think is essential—don't assume what those might be!
    c. **Be transparent**. Do not be translucent. Translucency has the same characteristics as transparency but is missing something that detracts and creates confusion and uncertainty. So, do not hide anything. Do not avoid including things. Just say what was. If you think even for a split second that you should include it, include it. If you think for a split second that you shouldn't or don't want to include something

("it'll be a hassle"), include it. It won't be as big of a hassle as it will be if you didn't include it.

3. **Do in Real-time**: Documenting activities as they happen, rather than trying to reconstruct your day later, maintains accuracy and builds trust in the process itself—and it's easier. If you do not do it in real-time, you won't be able to process your emotions and identify your needs healthily making them snowball into chaos later.
4. **Include Emotions**. Include your feelings and rate them (e.g., sad – 5/10). Then the journal is no longer data but a way to connect with yourself, with God and with others. It becomes a tool that not only builds integrity and trust but also rebuilds intimacy and connection. Not every entry needs an emotion, but the more you have them, the better the connection will be.

Making an Entry

The following are the basic components of an entry, which could be present in any order.

- **Time** (e.g., 08:00am, 4:30pm)
- **Location** (e.g., @work, @home, @church)
- **Activity** (e.g., client meeting; meeting about Project Avengers)
- **People** (e.g., client meeting with Jonathan)
- **Feeling**(s) (e.g., upset – 7, the order wasn't correct)
- **Extras** or Additional Information (e.g., bought lunch for $8.46)

Transparency increases when you tell not just what you did, but where were you, who was involved and how you engaged. Do not excuse or explain or mansplain.

The Time

The time should be in standard format unless specifically requested to be in military time by your spouse. The time slot should be in increments of 30 or 60 minutes.

The Location

Every entry should include where you were. If they are known places (home/work), then no additional information is needed. However, if you are away, "@hotel" is probably insufficient, especially if you have had affairs at hotels. You may need "@Marriott" and somewhere on the day provide details on the Marriott (e.g., address, hotel phone, room number, etc.). If you are at a location that is quite large, you may need to include more information. For example, for a mega church you may need something like "@church sanctuary" or "@church fellowship hall." Or if at the mall, "@Mall of NY–Store Name," which may also necessitate descriptions of stores you passed (e.g., a woman's intimate clothing store, etc.).

The Activity

This is the most basic component of an entry. Simply, it is the activity you were doing:

- Actions (e.g., "Checked email", "Read financial statements," "Talk with Bob about how to file an expense report," "Filed my April expense report," "Read espn.com," etc.)
- Transitions (e.g., "Drove to work," "Got gas on the way")
- Conversations (e.g., "Spoke to receptionist; brief greeting only")
- Etc.

Avoid generalities like "Worked all day." Break it down:

- 9:00–9:30: Arrived at work, got coffee, checked voicemail (6 from men; 1 from a woman) and made notes to respond

- 9:30-10:00: Responded to emails (2 from female clients: Jessica R., Amy W.)

The People

It is also recommended that every entry—where relevant—include where you were and names of people with whom you interacted (e.g., "@work, got a drink from snack bar, talked with Cheryl about the weather").

The Feeling(s)

There are so many benefits to including feelings in your entries. To name a few:

- *Personal Congruence*: It will help you connect with yourself and become aware of what's going on inside of you, which will help prevent you from all sorts of future bad behaviors.
- *Recollection*: It will help you remember how you felt at various points of the day as you try to recall the day to journal or share with your spouse.
- *Root Work*: Some items require more work at a later time. This journal can serve as a springboard into that root work.
- *Relational Intimacy*: It changes the journal from being just data, to a point of connection with your spouse.

To add a feeling, it can be simple as mad, sad, glad, angry, lonely, hurt, shame, and guilt or including more complex feeling names or states of beings (e.g., confused, disappointed, etc.). You also do want to include the three I's—insignificance, incompetence, and impotence—as much as possible.

Finally, briefly describe the reason(s) why you are feeling the way you feel.

Here are a few examples:

- “@work, tried creating a macro in Excel, fear of not completing it on-time – 8; incompetent – 9”
- “@home, worked on the house with <spouse>, glad – 10”
- “@softball field, angry at Bob for making 5 errors which cost us the game – 9†”
  † This probably should be reconsidered when journaling later because under that anger is probably sadness, fear (reputation), shame (embarrassment), and/or guilt (for yelling).

The Extras

Depending on the nature of your job, your personal growth goals, your integrity issues, and the requests from your spouse, sponsor, coach or counselor, you should include more information about the place, activity, people or feelings. For example, if you have lost trust with money, you may want to include financial transactions if relevant to the entry. If you have had an affair or struggle with sexual integrity issues, then you want to add names and genders of anyone with whom you interact, especially people of the sex of your affairs.

Here are some examples:

- Struggle with lying:
  - “talked with John about sports; lied about the number of goals I scored when I played soccer.”
  - “talked with Sam about fishing; no lies.”
- Struggle with money:
  - “got gas at the pump - $45.99; did not purchase anything extra; receipt was sent to you via text.”
  - “@CFA, lunch, $15.44 – got a large drink; paid for Bob’s lunch.”
    Note: “got a large drink” is added here because normally I don’t get a large, and this time I did. I could have hidden that in with “paid for Bob’s lunch,” but that would have been deceptive.

This demonstrates transparency and complete honesty.

- Struggle with affairs:
    - "@work, @snack bar, talked with Sally about her school."
    - "arrived @Marriott Courtyard (details ^), checked-in, went to my room; the receptionist was a woman; only spoke about the hotel stay; she asked, 'how I was doing?' I only gave a short answer, 'well' and did not extend the conversation walking away."
    - "@Outback, work dinner, sat beside Bob and Sam, Bob changed seats with Sally during dessert."
- Struggle with internet pornography:
    - "@work, @desk, prepared/sent email to my boss."
    - "@home, couch, streamed Netflix 'Swiss Family Robinson'"
    - "@mall, saw VS and looked for too long"
    - "@church, looked on <inappropriate website> on my phone" spouse.

This level of detail reflects the transparency you're trying to build. The amount of work you put into the journal will dictate how much you get from the journal.

Share Your Journal

Finally, *share* the Time Journal with your spouse. This gives you an opportunity for connection. It is *not* for the simple transmission of data or facts. It is *not* for defending yourself (or even preparing a future defense). It is *not* for gaining affirmation or validation from your spouse. It is *not* for convincing your spouse of anything.

The First Rule of the Journal

The first rule of the journal is:

Your spouse can view your journal whenever, wherever, however he/she wants without your permission.

Your spouse can *view your journal.* If the journal is digital, it should be shared with her immediately. If you create a new document for each day, then it needs to be shared with her immediately. Do not make her have to go look for the journal or have to ask you for the journal.

Your spouse can view your journal *whenever*, at 5am before you are awake, at midnight, during lunch, in the middle of a conversation, before sex, etc.

Your spouse can review your journal *wherever* he/she is. She can ask for it while he/she is out of town, while you are out of town, at home, at a friend's house, at his/her parent's house, in the yard, on a plane, etc.

Your spouse can review it however he/she pleases. He/She can require your presence or your absence. He/She can do it on the phone or in person with a counselor, couch, or sponsor/mentor though boundaries should be set about whether she can share what's in the journal with friends and family.

Your Goal

Make this the Goal: your spouse should never have to ask to see your journal without your permission.

Preparing for the Conversations

Before having any of these conversations, you need to *prepare yourself* to receive feedback and possibly criticism, doubt, concern, laughter, and disagreement. The conversation may be difficult, even if the day was a "good" day. Once I had what I thought was a "great" day, but when I shared that with my spouse, she highlighted all the reasons why the day was horrible, all of which were because of something I did or didn't do that I said I would do. Here are a few tips to prepare:

- **Body**: Open posture (e.g., nothing clenched, nothing crossed), "soft face, soft heart," avoid bracing for impact, manage your anxiety manifestations (e.g., nail biting, etc)
- **Soul**: Pray "Lord, help me to receive *him/her* well." Focus on the entire person, not just the accusations or data.
- **Mind**: "This is my wife/husband whom I love." They are not the enemy, interrogator, accuser, attorney, or any other villain. Do not look for cracks or inaccurate or unfactual information. Do not explain anything! Your spouse needs to be heard. Focus on his/her feelings.
- **Heart**: Be empathetic and tender. Connect to his/her vulnerability. Recognize your spouse's feelings—their fear, anxiety, and/or anger.

Do NOT:

- Expect equanimity or your spouse to be open, receptive, empathetic, or understanding of you. Instead focus on taking ownership and demonstrating responsibility.
- Talk in the middle of his/her pauses. Instead, give him/her the time she needs to collect their thoughts.
- Correct them or tell them they are being illogical or say their assumptions were wrong about you. Instead, focus on the feelings behind the statements and ask if your spouse would like to hear what you were thinking.
- Complete their thoughts/sentences. Instead, let your spouse say whatever in their own words giving her a voice.
- Focus on outcome management or emotional manipulation. Instead, be present and be honest, even if it makes you look bad.

The Conversations

These conversations should happen iteratively with your spouse. They can be all together in one conversation or multiple conversations or parts of parts of conversations. They

can be daily, weekly, monthly, or annually. The conversations should be driven by you, not by your spouse or by their request.

Discuss Expectations

Ask your spouse about their expectations for when you review the journal with them.

- Do they want to review the journal daily? weekly? monthly? Or, at all?
- How do they want to review the journal? Hour by hour? Day by day? Highlight by highlight? Only activities with specific extras? Only activities with feelings?

Note: Your spouse doesn't have to give you an answer about any of these things. Do not use this to give you an excuse not to review the journal with them. If they say they do not want you to review it with them, periodically offer to review it with them.

Do not assume that because you asked once that you do not need to ask again or that you get everything she needs and wants. Be fluid and flexible allowing the expectations to change.

Discuss the Journal

Proactively share the journal with her. If possible, at the end of each day, sit down with your spouse to review the journal. Don't just hand it to her. Start a conversation. Ask your spouse if you can share your day with him/her. Bring it to a conversation ready to discuss highs, lows, and buffalos (i.e., anything weird, random, or out of the ordinary).

Next, and possibly most importantly, invite them to ask questions about your journal every time. Inviting your spouse to ask questions demonstrates openness and humility and creates space for them.

This isn't an interrogation but an opportunity for you to practice transparency and communication. This is an opportunity to build trust, create safety, and to love well, even if the conversation and discussion is difficult.

If a question is asked, something seems unclear, or a concern is raised, practice empathy, understand her concerns, and address the question and concern openly and humbly rather than defensively. Leverage the discussion to solicit more information to make your entries better. Does your spouse need more information? Less information? Specific information?

For example, if your spouse asks, "Who's Joan?" based on an entry, that's an *opportunity*—not an attack. Clarify in a way that fosters security and connection. Don't make her find the truth—offer it. Answer her questions about Joan before she asks them. If the person is attractive, say so; if not, don't highlight that as it will seem like you're minimizing or even lying.

If, for whatever reason, you cannot share it with your spouse in person, then try these options:

- Send the journal (or a picture of the journal with the date) via text or email—they should be able to see the journal as you discuss it.
- Call your spouse and review it with them on the phone.
- If you are unable to communicate via phone, then in your email or text message always include an invitation for her to ask questions or discuss it.

Special Considerations (NEEDS WORK)

There are several special considerations to keep in mind when implementing the Time Journal:

Work Constraints (NEEDS WORK)

For those whose work involves confidentiality or security clearances, be thoughtful about how you document your activities. You can still be accountable without breaching professional confidentiality. Where possible, include as much information as possible.

However, you may also need to consider a career change, especially if your spouse is not comfortable with the vague

Travel and Unusual Circumstances (NEEDS WORK)

When traveling or in unusual circumstances, maintain your journal practice but adapt as needed. This might mean using your phone to take notes or sending updates more frequently. During these times, extra communication can help ease anxiety about being apart. Regardless, you eventually want to make sure that all your entries are in one place when the specific circumstance has passed.

Inquiring Minds (NEEDS WORK)

Be sure you have thought through how you are going to answer people when they ask about what you are doing and why you are doing it. You need to be honest and transparent with them too. And you also want to hold your spouse in high esteem and maintain his/her confidence.

A Note to Spouses

For the spouse of someone implementing a Time Journal, this tool may bring up mixed emotions. You might feel relief at having more transparency, resentment at needing this level of accountability, or skepticism about its effectiveness. Here are some thoughts to consider:

- **Your role is *not* to verify every entry**. While you have every right to question entries that seem vague or concerning, the journal's primary purpose is to shift the burden of accountability to your husband. This should alleviate your need to investigate. If you are feeling the need to play “private investigator,” then you need to communicate your needs.
- **Communicate your needs**. Be clear about what information is helpful to you—and even what information is not. Your spouse should be asking you if you need more information, less information, or specific

information. Your input can help make this tool more effective for your specific situation. And yes, sadly, you may need to tell him/her *again*.

- **Recognize growth over time**. Recognize your own growth. Recognize your partner's growth or that growth happens gradually. There is even growth in the process. And sometimes, the growth appears to not be progress. Also, remember, this process will take years.
- **Be okay with being skeptical**. Your skepticism is valid. Give yourself permission to feel uncertain while still allowing space for this tool to potentially help your relationship heal.

Final Thoughts and Encouragement

The Time Journal is more than a simple record of activities—it's a daily practice of integrity and transparency. At first, it may feel burdensome or even intrusive, but many find that over time, it becomes an invaluable tool—not only for rebuilding trust, but for living with greater intentionality and purpose.

Keep in mind: the goal isn't perfection, but progress. There will be days when you miss entries or overlook details. That's okay. What truly matters is your consistent commitment to accountability and your willingness to keep going, even when you fall short.

Rebuilding trust is a journey, not a destination. No matter how far you've come, you're always just a few steps from slipping back. Even in the most mature and secure stages of a relationship, your spouse may still need reassurance of your trustworthiness—and that's normal.

The Time Journal is just one tool among many that can help lay the foundation for lasting trust and intimacy. By committing to this process, you're not merely documenting your steps; you're intentionally shaping the path toward the person God is calling you to become—someone marked by integrity, transparency, and faithfulness.

You can rebuild trust. Not instantly, but steadily—through time, effort, and a willingness to grow.

Finally, you do not need this journal to keep doing the Time Journal. Feel free to use something else, a blank paper you print, a spiral notebook, a leather journal, or some digital application. Regardless, choose something that's easy, accessible and available. Simplicity helps sustain the habit. The most important thing is not where you journal but that you just do it.

The Journals…

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Additional Tools

See these other tools...